

4.1 Values of water

TEACHER SHEETS

Instructions

There are four teacher sheets provided, one for each value of water (economic, cultural, spiritual, aesthetic). Print them out and place each one in a different corner of the room. At each station, include additional images or graphs that you find.

Provide students the worksheet provided at the end. Have them rotate through the different stations, learning about the different values of water. Then have them answer the comprehension questions.

Economic value of water

What this value means

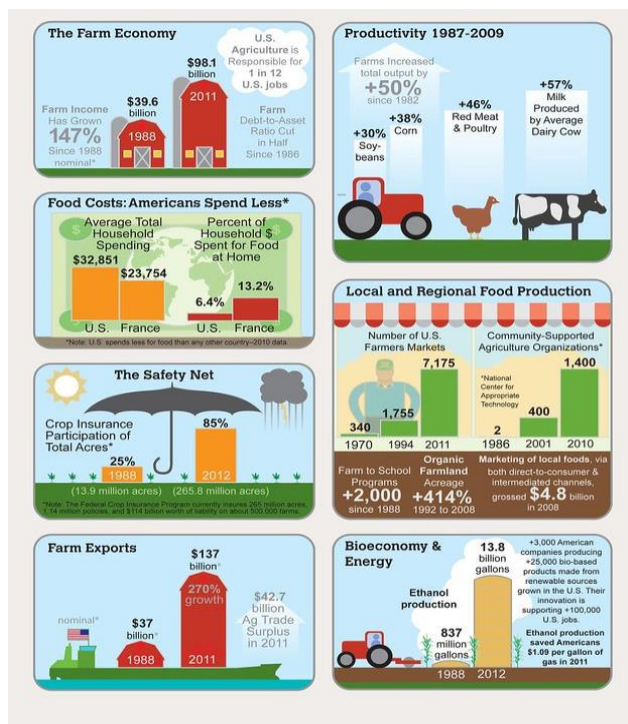
Water is a key resource that allows economies to function. It supports industries, creates employment and generates income for communities and countries. Without reliable water, many economic activities—especially farming and manufacturing—cannot operate. Water is also needed for producing energy, transporting goods and supporting tourism.

Why it matters

Water is essential for keeping economies running. Without reliable water, farms cannot grow food, industries cannot produce goods and energy systems like hydropower cannot operate. Communities depend on water for jobs, income and basic services. When water becomes scarce or poor in quality, the cost of living rises, businesses struggle and households face financial stress. Understanding the economic value of water helps us see why governments invest in dams, pipelines and treatment plants to ensure a stable supply.

Examples

- Agriculture: irrigation grows crops like rice, cotton, sugarcane, fruit and vegetables.
- Hydropower: flowing water generates renewable electricity.
- Tourism: rivers, lakes and beaches attract tourists, supporting hotels, guides and local businesses
- Mining and industry: water is needed for processing ore, cooling machinery and producing goods.



Cultural value of water

What this value means

Water is deeply connected to the identity, traditions and practices of different cultures around the world. Communities often use water in celebrations, ceremonies and daily customs passed down through generations. Water can symbolise life, renewal, cleansing, community and belonging.

Why it matters

Water plays an important role in shaping identities, traditions and community life. Many cultural celebrations, stories and daily practices involve rivers, rain, oceans or water creatures. These traditions help connect people to their ancestors, their community and their sense of place. When access to culturally important water sites is reduced or damaged, cultural practices can be disrupted or lost. Recognising the cultural value of water reminds us that it is not just a physical resource—it carries meaning that strengthens communities and preserves heritage.

Examples

- Cultural festivals involving water, such as ritual cleansing, blessing ceremonies or New Year water events.
- Traditional fishing practices used by First Nations and other cultural groups.
- Community swimming spots where families gather for recreation and connection.
- Cultural stories and Dreaming narratives that explain the creation of rivers, springs and waterholes.
- Foods, crafts and livelihoods connected to local water environments.



"ALCUSTOM AL25 - spearfish" by ALCUSTOMBOATS is marked with Public Domain



"Baptism at Northolt Park Baptist Church (cropped) (cropped)" by brett jordan is licensed under CC BY 2.0.

Spiritual value of water

What this value means

Many groups view water as sacred or spiritually significant. Water may represent healing, protection, purity or connection to Country. For many First Nations Peoples, water is part of a living landscape that holds ancestors, law and knowledge.

Why it matters

For many people and cultures, water is sacred and linked to belief systems, healing and connection to Country. Water sources can hold deep spiritual significance, guiding cultural law, stories and responsibilities. Losing access to these places can harm spiritual wellbeing and disconnect people from their cultural roots. Understanding the spiritual value of water encourages respectful management of rivers, springs and waterholes, especially for First Nations communities who have cared for these places for thousands of years.

Examples

- Sacred rivers, springs or waterholes used for prayer, offerings or ceremonies.
- Ritual cleansing practices in diverse religions.
- Meditation or reflection spaces beside lakes, rivers or oceans.
- First Nations water sites that are central to stories, kinship systems and custodial responsibilities.



Aesthetic value of water

What this value means

Water adds beauty, inspiration and enjoyment to natural and built landscapes. People value places with water because they are visually appealing, calming and often used for recreation. These places can improve mental health and enrich everyday life.

Why it matters

Water makes environments more beautiful, calming and enjoyable. Many people spend time near water to relax, exercise or appreciate natural scenery, which can improve mental health and quality of life. Attractive water landscapes also support tourism and make towns and cities more pleasant places to live. When water places are polluted or degraded, people lose access to spaces that contribute to happiness, recreation and wellbeing. Recognising the aesthetic value of water helps us understand why protecting natural beauty is an important part of environmental management.

Examples

- Beaches, waterfalls, lakes and rivers are admired for their beauty.
- Scenic lookouts over bays, cascades or estuaries.
- Urban waterfronts (e.g., Sydney Harbour) that enhance city aesthetics.
- Art, photography and film that use water to create mood or drama.
- Recreational spaces like swimming spots, canoeing areas, walking tracks beside rivers.



Student worksheet

Value	Describe the value	Example from station	How this value influences people or place
Economic			
Cultural			
Spiritual			
Aesthetic			

Answer the following in your book.

1. Which value of water (economic, cultural, spiritual or aesthetic) do you think influences people's lives the most? Explain your reasoning using examples from the stations.
2. Choose one water place you know (local river, beach, lake, dam, creek or wetland). Describe how this place holds at least two different types of value for people.
3. How might conflicts arise when different groups value the same water place in different ways? Give an example (real or hypothetical)